He nodded and I thought: *What about the World Cup?* And I slumped back.

‘I can’t believe this is happening.’

They got me onto a stretcher and took me around the side of the field to the dressing room: there was no other way but past the photographers. I couldn’t remember the last time I’d had to come off injured during a game. Throughout my career, I’d been so lucky. Why had that luck run out now? I looked up towards where Victoria always sat when she came to Old Trafford. She was on her feet straight away and I saw her pick up Brooklyn and make her way downstairs. When I got into the treatment room, I asked one of the lads to fetch her. I knew she’d be worried. I expected her to be even more upset than I was but Victoria was really strong for me during those moments when it was all starting to sink in.

‘Don’t worry,’ she said. ‘It’ll get fixed. Everything’s going to be fine.’

Brooklyn was there too. He wasn’t sure what was going on.

‘Why aren’t you playing any more, Daddy? What’s happened to your leg?’

Laughing at my boy didn’t do me any harm just then either. I knew we were going straight to the hospital.

‘Hey, Brooklyn. We’re going in an ambulance.’

His eyes widened:

‘Are we?’

Doctor Noble, the United surgeon, was in the treatment room with us. I wanted to know there and then:

‘What’s the longest I’ll be out?’

‘We’ll know as soon as I’ve seen the x-ray.’

They got me down to the ambulance and agreed that it would be all right for Victoria and Brooklyn to come with us. Once we’d all got inside, they strapped me to a bed so that my foot wouldn’t move around on the way. I got the driver to stick the blue light on for Brooklyn. At least it was turning into